

Tech in SAR's First Grade

A parent-organized survey

June 11, 2025

Participation in the survey

► Survey Distribution:

- Fully anonymous
- Open for 7 days, with one announcement and one reminder email
- Sent to all parents in the kindergarten directory, with unique links so each survey can be taken once only. Thus there is no “gaming” with people answering multiple times.

► High response rate

- Normal response rate for [Gallup](#) or [Pew](#) is 20-30%
- 75.5% of kindergarten children had at least one parent respond

Technical details

► Survey response interpretation

- Incomplete surveys were included for the questions they answered
- Reported statistics weight each child equally, regardless of whether one or two parents responded. Thus if two parents responded, the responses are averaged to make one response for the child. If only one parent responded, their response is counted for the child
- Parents of twins had the option to submit the same preferences for both children or separate preferences for their two kindergartners

► Coloring

- Green bars shows responses **more** enthusiastic about technology
- Red bars show responses **less** enthusiastic about technology
- Labels are also included for red-green colorblind people

► More details on survey construction in the FAQ

Components

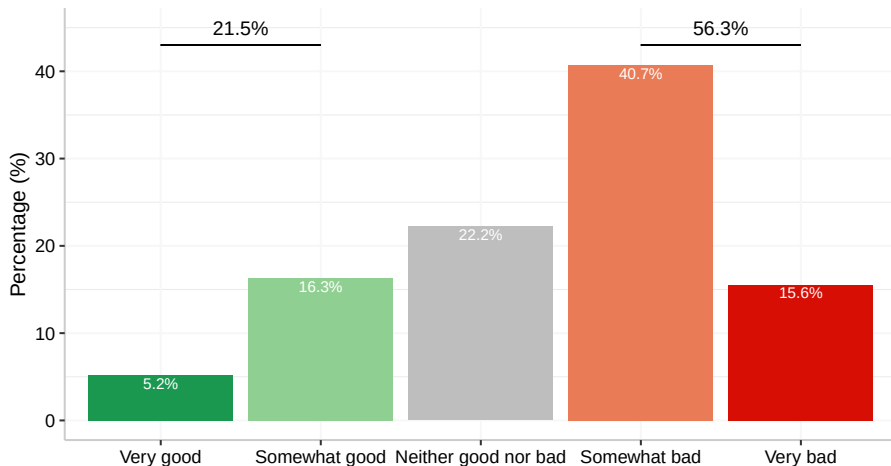
① Beliefs & Preferences

② Uses of Technology

③ Free-Response

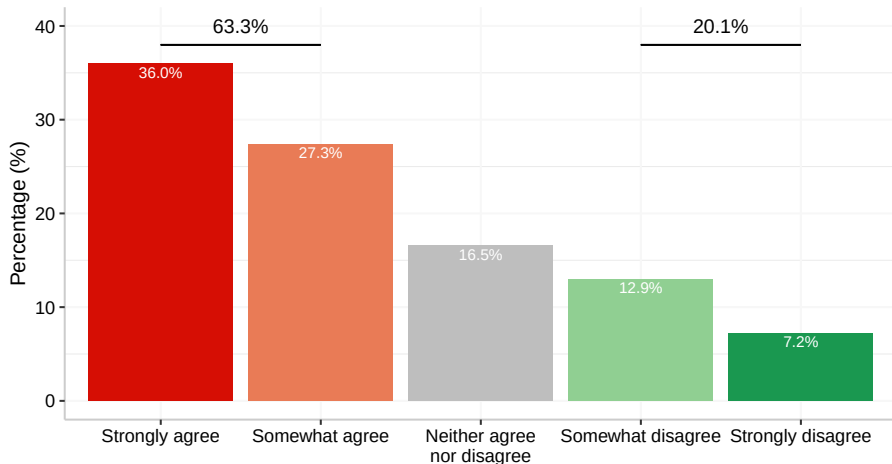
④ FAQ

What impact do you think ipads at school have on your first-grader's education?



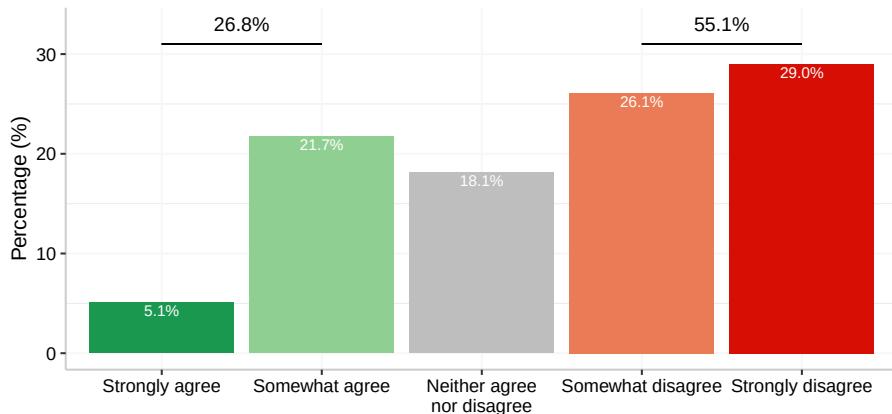
How much do you agree with the following statements?

I do not want my first-grader to use iPads at school



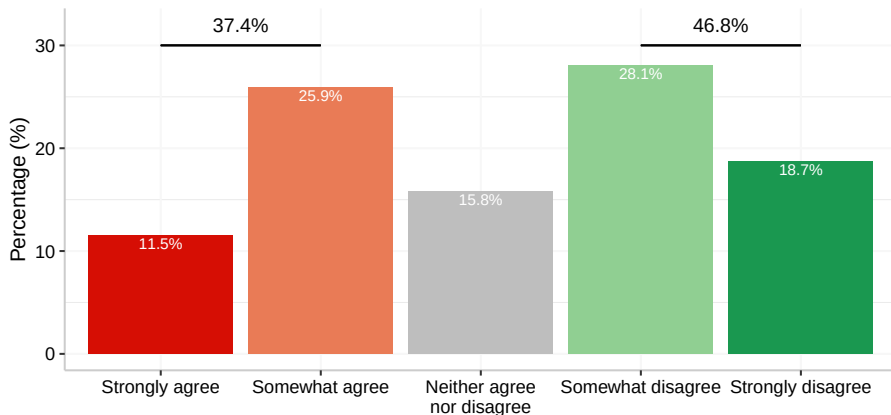
How much do you agree with the following statements?

I think it is educationally helpful for my first-grader to use an iPad at school



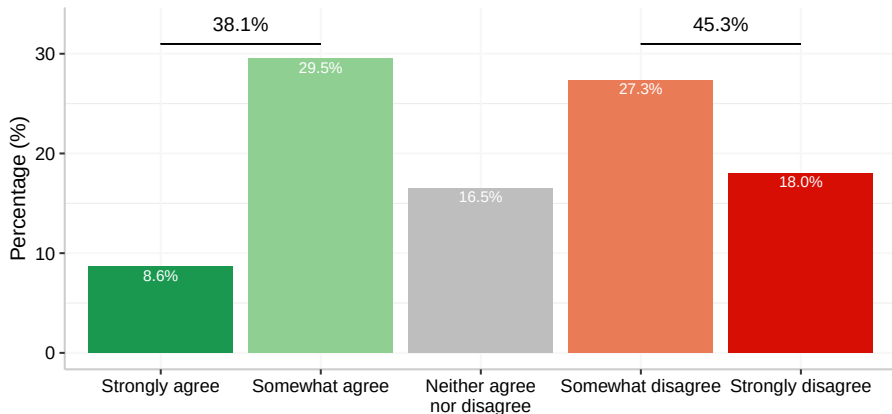
How much do you agree with the following statements?

I believe elementary school children will access inappropriate material online when given access to iPads



How much do you agree with the following statements?

I think first-graders will develop key technology-literacy skills when using iPads in school



Components

① Beliefs & Preferences

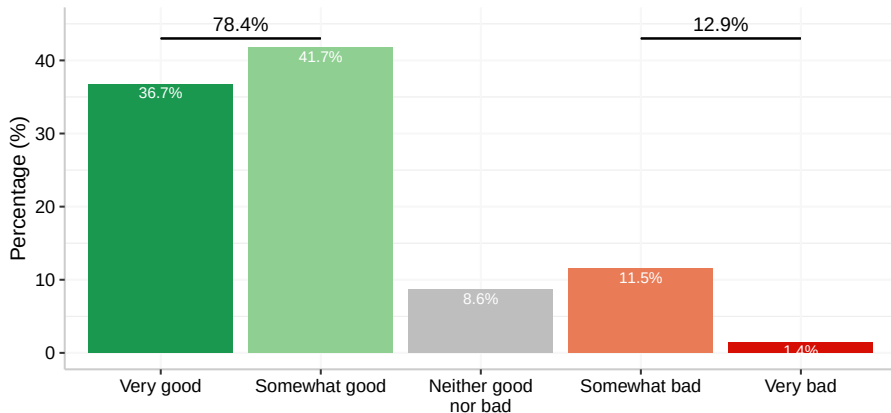
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④ FAQ

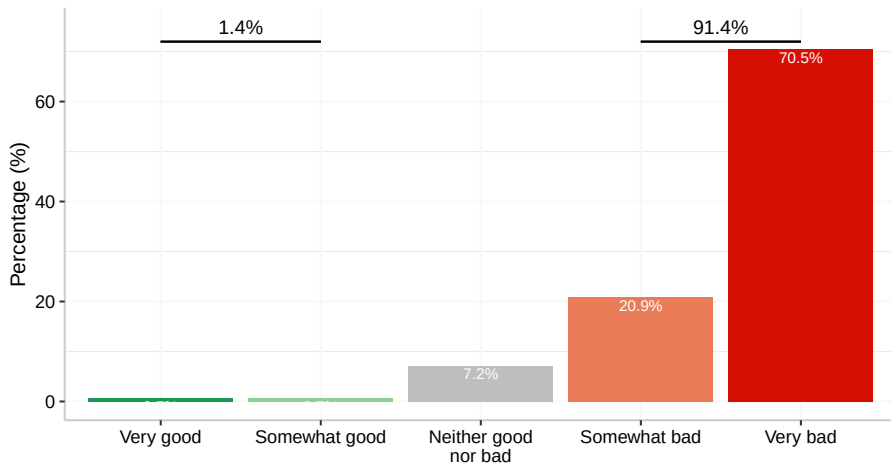
How do you feel about this use of tech in 1st grade?

A movie to show what a Rube Goldberg Machine is or show something else that is hard to explain



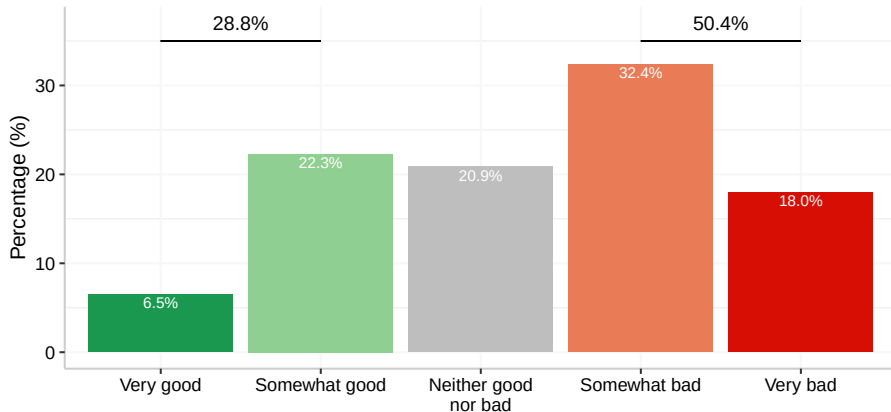
How do you feel about this use of tech in 1st grade?

A movie during snack/lunch to distract



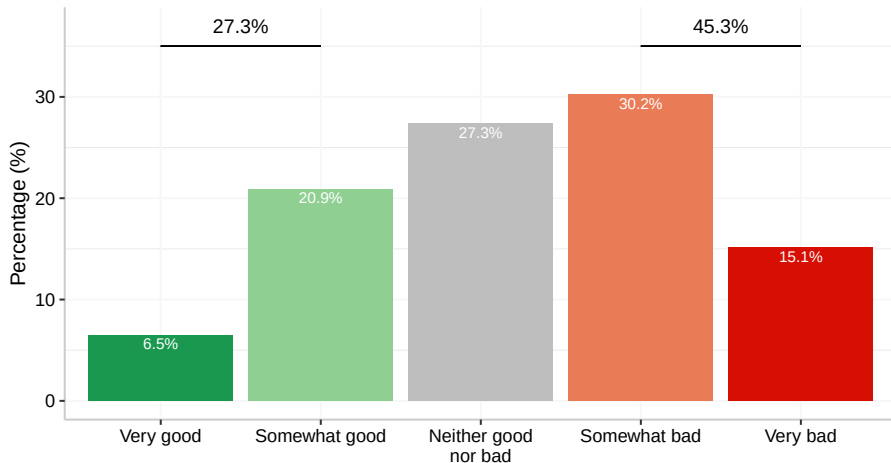
How do you feel about this use of tech in 1st grade?

An iPad swiping/highlighting game to supplement the Hebrew curriculum



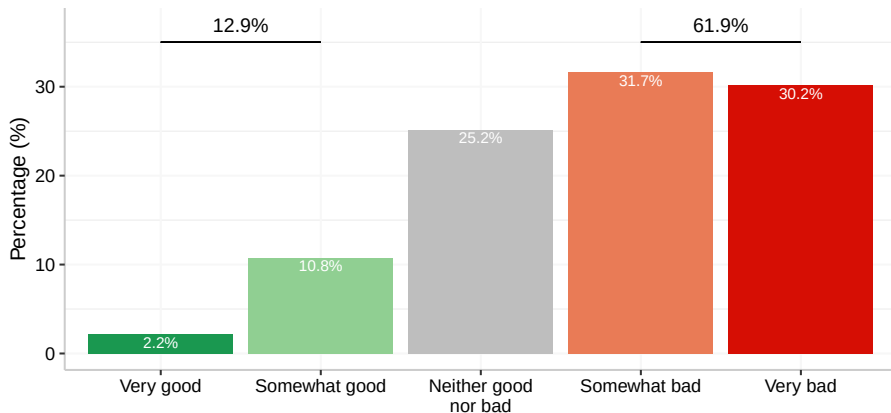
How do you feel about this use of tech in 1st grade?

A video to guide movement, exercise or meditation

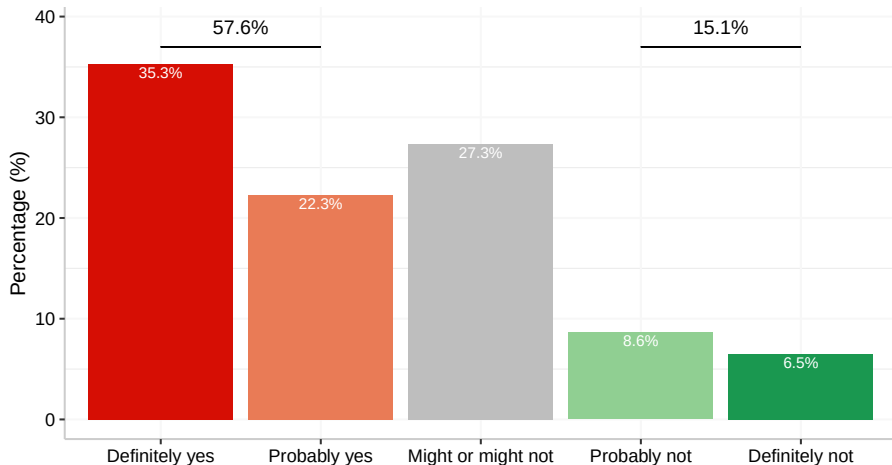


How do you feel about this use of tech in 1st grade?

A video showing actors reading a children's book aloud (by Storyline)



If there was an iPad-free first-grade option, I would want that for my child



Components

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④ FAQ

Parent's Comments

Is there anything you'd like to share with the school?

- ▶ All comments parents submitted are included in the following 12 pages
- ▶ These comments are in parents' own words. One comment that was sent to the survey administrator, but seemed relevant is included. One comment to the survey administrator (rather than the school) and obviously identifying information have been edited out.
- ▶ Comments are presented in a random order.

Parent's Comments

- ① When our older son was in first grade, he would tell us that if he finished his work quickly, he got to use the ipad. We were very concerned about this and the way it structurally reinforces kids for rushing through their work to get ipad time. It should simply never be used as an incentive or reward or for kids who are done with work early.
- ② You are amazing educators who think deeply about how best to help our children navigate a complicated and interconnected world. Thank you
- ③ We take significant efforts to limit iPad access at home. While we do sometimes allow it, we find that the net effect is unfortunately not positive (e.g., leads to dependency and greater difficulty moving on to an activity/task away from a screen) and would therefore be inclined to substantially limit it in a school setting, especially in situations where there is a viable alternative that does not involve screen time.

Parent's Comments

- ④ I don't think iPads should be used to supplement education. If you feel there should be a course on coding or something of the sort at a young age then that's different but it shouldn't be used to read the kids stories or in place of a teacher doing a lesson.
- ⑤ I would very much prefer that my child be in an iPad free class.
- ⑥ I see the value if iPads are used to compliment learning in ways that the teachers cannot.

If they are used as a babysitting tool - and for something that a teacher or person could do instead, I don't see the benefit and I would very strongly prefer a person to an iPad. I don't think iPads are inherently bad if they are used thoughtfully, purposefully and infrequently.

Parent's Comments

- ⑦ Technology is part of life today and tech literacy is part of a good STEM background. That said, it is also addictive and I see how screen time hypnotizes kids and can render them glassy eyed and unable to focus on anything else. Which is all to say: I am fine with technology in first grade and even iPad time for purposes such as some mentioned above but I firmly believe that iPads should be used sparingly and only in highly considered situations.
- ⑧ If the school is not able to fully lock the devices from any internet access, it is negligent to give them devices. If we don't give our kids devices at home, it feels sad to send them to school to have them exposed there.
- ⑨ Our kids get more than enough screen time at home, so I would prefer for them to engage with their peers and teachers than have ANOTHER screen, unless it really makes sense to teach them a topic or accomplish a learning objective.

Parent's Comments

- 10 Our child is exposed to devices through older siblings and we would like to minimize exposure at school. (We are not opposed to iPad use in school for older kids). As for videos, we prefer to have real, live wonderful teachers teaching kids as opposed to screens – unless the video truly delivers something that a teacher cannot easily teach or demonstrate (like the rube goldberg machine or, perhaps, meditation – but in that instance, we would expect that the teacher would be participating in the meditation along with the class as a model!). Children gain so much from their teachers – they are not replaceable! :)
- 11 Some of these questions felt biased and leading. I can't imagine anyone will want a child watching a movie during lunch when kids should be socializing. Tech is still critical for children to learn at this age. All public schools are using tech. Our children will fall behind if we remove tech from the curriculum. iPads and computers can be used in many ways to enhance learning.

Parent's Comments

- 12 The school is so thoughtful and so amazing in so many domains—this is one of the only areas where I don't see the characteristic thoughtfulness. My kids don't access phones or iPads at home and it is disappointing to me that the school makes this parenting choice much harder to maintain, with minimal educational benefit.
- 13 I think technology could have a place in the classroom, however it should not **REPLACE** anything that would otherwise be enhanced by the student-teacher relationship (i.e., a video should not replace a teacher reading a book, or teaching a concept).
Additionally, videos should **ABSOLUTELY** not be used as a distraction device during down time.
- 14 Technology can't and shouldn't substitute for a teacher teaching. The children should be interacting with each other and the teacher(s) and not an iPad or any technology.

Parent's Comments

- 15 SAR is not overly using iPads or technology in the lower grades. In fact, I appreciated the technology survey last year. I do not feel this survey reflects first grade.
- 16 As a pediatrician, I am concerned about the impact of screen time, both in school and at home, on children's development (academic and social-emotional) and mental health. I believe that working through a question/problem/reading passage with a teacher, watching it being solved on a blackboard, is significantly more beneficial than watching it being solved on a video. Lastly, if devices are to be used, I think that devices that require typing (computers, Google Chromes, etc) are more beneficial than iPads and other tablets because typing is an important skill (although likely not until after 1st grade).
- 17 Thank you for providing opportunities for individualized learning through assistive devices and technology for all types of learners. And for having an abundance of devices and technology staffing to make it happen!

Parent's Comments

- 18 I believe it is bad for a first grader to have consistent daily access to an iPad to supplement their education. Sure, it is impossible to avoid screens entirely and I agree there is a time and place for educational videos and digital supplemental educational material. But first grade is neither the time nor place to develop 'key' technology literacy, that will undoubtedly happen naturally in today's screen-filled world. I beg that additional screens NOT be incorporated into the first grade curriculum
- 19 move away from screens! they are not helping our children!
- 20 This is a very important topic as I ****strongly**** agree, as many SAR parents do, that there should be less technology for our children at SAR and that there should be a very low technology/iPad free option for first grade. Please adhere to this and lower the amount of technology used and strongly consider this option for first grade. There are so many benefits of interaction without technology for these young children (for their learning, their social skills, their physical development, etc etc), and such a loss when teachers and students have to rely on technology.

Parent's Comments

- 21 While we do not feel strongly that the use of iPads will have an adverse effect on first-graders, our overall feeling is that it is not wholly necessary. Our preference would be to use it to enhance literacy, and not to replace traditional learning methods.
- 22 Kids should not be using screens in school. Leads to distracted kids, poor sleep, poor mental health, poor communication skills etc
- 23 There are a few things I can see utilizing screens for (I recently found this and showed it to my kids: <https://neal.fun/deep-sea/>); the Rube Goldberg movie seems reasonable enough. But these "necessities" are very few and far between, and I think ultimately iPads are unnecessary for children at this age. Not to be all "IN MY DAY" but seriously in my day we learned well enough without anything shiny like this, so I trust it can be done now, too.
- 24 In my view, iPads are not appropriate tools for first grade children for a myriad of reasons that are well documented and should be removed from the curriculum in their entirety.

Parent's Comments

- 25 While I view many of the specific examples included in this survey as inherently neutral in themselves, I strongly dislike the heavy presence of technology in the classroom. Skills and activities that can be conducted without the use of a screen should be done that way when possible (eg read aloud stories). While I appreciate that they give teachers a break, which is valuable, and keep children engaged because of the excitement of a screen, the screen itself detrimental, and superfluous to the activity. There is plenty of time for children to learn tech literacy in later elementary school, no one will be without exposure to technology if it is utilized slightly less in the classroom, but they do miss out on developing more “analog” skills by focusing so heavily on tech use from such an early point.
- 26 iPads should be used sparingly for supplemental learning. I do think there is value in learning games that help reinforce concepts taught. However iPads for the sake of “tech literacy” is limited as kids learn technology quickly and easily. Using technology to reinforce basic coding should be introduced but that can be taught without iPads (I've seen creative games where robot has buttons to teach kids logic commands) that kind of literacy is very valuable to be taught early.

Parent's Comments

- 27 As long as the iPad is being used to supplement education, I don't have an issue it's when it's used as a replacement tool or a dominant method of teaching
- 28 I have been extremely happy with the education my children are receiving at SAR and my children love school. I trust the administration and teachers, experts in their field, to make thoughtful decisions about education and how they implement technology in the classroom.
- 29 While I do not allow TV and movies in my home, I know that there are many tools on devices that benefit teaching, help with engagement, and keep our children excited about learning. There is no such thing as no screen time in the world we live in, although I do try to create a home with the more limited screen time possible and I trust the educators are doing their best to find a balance
- 30 The note above about the video of the Rube Goldberg machine is a video I want my children to see. I want them to see it as a collective (on a shared TV screen) and not on an iPad where they are not working in a group

Parent's Comments

- 31 Some of these questions don't share the alternative - ie we prefer a teacher reading aloud in real time a section of a book to first graders over a video. However, if the alternative is decreased reading opportunities for varied levels of readers, we might find it less bothersome, as read alouds for emerging readers is an important tool.

Again, similar to Ivrit. We recognize that using the I-Talam which is based on iPad/technology overall has been a strong Ivrit program. It feels hard to isolate one aspect of the curricula in a vacuum without understanding the highlighting game role within the larger curricula. When they used to teach typing back in the 90's they also supplemented it with typing games - though not identical - I think we appreciate different mediums of games to reinforce skills.

We would like to think that the school is continuing to analyze their technology policies and use (or overuse) and ensure appropriate utilization within the classroom and curricula. We would like to see them limited but in our experience first graders spend little time on iPads during the school day.

Parent's Comments

- 32 Honestly I don't know the objective data on this subject. Clearly there are a lot of opinions out there (and if this is all just people's opinions, then we should be honest and agree we don't know) but I'm guessing it's been formally studied and someone has measured its impact on an interpretable or relevant outcome? Without the data, I'm sure there are parents conflating all kinds of personal feelings they have about technology and the companies that own them, with their own anecdotes, politics, and probably whatever is popping up on their TikTok. I am not an expert here and I would like to listen to an expert on this and have them guide me.
- 33 As a child psychiatrist concerned with the development of kids- I'm strongly aligned and of the belief that screens are detrimental. Many progressive educational institutions are getting rid of technology based learning given the detrimental impact on kids' learning and attention. I'd much prefer hands-on, in person engagement. Additionally, our older child has talked about how kids are incentivized to rush through work knowing that once finished they can use the iPad. I worry that its use is interfering with developing a child's capacity to work slowly and thoughtfully.

Components

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④ FAQ

FAQ

► **Why did you run this survey? Didn't the school do a survey?**

This was a parent-organized and parent-administered survey, meant to inform discussion about first-grade in particular. Since parents may have different opinions about what is suitable for an 8th grader and for a 1st grader, it seemed reasonable to focus this survey narrowly.

Further, it seemed possible that we may not all be aware of the other parents' (nuanced) opinions, so I hoped this would be an opportunity to constructively bring us into conversation with a broader shared community.

FAQ

► How was the survey constructed?

- I drafted it and it was reviewed by one parent who likes technology, one parent who does not, and one non-parent who is an expert in survey design.
- It included several standard features to ensure non-biased results
 - Both pros and cons of technology are included.
 - The default response switches regularly.
 - Results are weighted by child, rather than by parent response.
- Uses of technology listed are based on SAR students' and parents' reports of current uses in first grade specifically.

FAQ

► **Is it biased/leading to ask question like “I do not want my first-grader to use iPads at school” or “I think it is educationally helpful for my first-grader to use an iPad at school” have opinions baked in?**

Survey questions that include a potentially-charged statement with the options to agree or disagree are a very common way of eliciting a range of opinions. These statements included both positive and negative statements about some of the impacts that parents may think about, and the order of appearance was randomized. Here are examples from the General Social Survey:

- “Most men are better suited emotionally for politics than are most women.” Asked since 1974. ([Source](#))
- “A working mother can establish just as warm and secure a relationship with her children as a mother who does not work.” Since 1977. ([Source](#))

Contact

► One note

Four respondents got a survey that included a question about a smartwatch before I noticed it was still in the survey. It was removed and the data automatically deleted. Sorry for any confusion.

► Any questions or comments on this survey can be directed to natalia.emanuel@gmail.com.